The Character of Jewish Apocalyptic

Primary Characteristics

- *Special Disclosures*
- *Dualism of Powers*
- *Dualism of Ages*
- *Symbolism*
- *Cosmic Disturbances*
- *Angelology/Demonology*
- *Messianic Figure*

Apocalyptic Literature

Roots in the Old Testament Canon

- Isaiah 24-27, 34-35, 65-66
- Zechariah 9-11, 12-14
- Daniel 2, 7, 9, 10-12

In the Apocrypha

- 2 Esdras

In the Pseudepigrapha

- Apocalypse of Abraham
- Apocalypse of Adam
- 2 Baruch
- 3 Baruch
- Apocalypse of Daniel
- Apocalypse of Elijah
- 1 Enoch
- 2 Enoch
- 3 Enoch
- Apocryphon of Ezekiel
- Greek Apocalpyse of Ezra
- Revelation of Ezra
- Vision of Ezra
- Jubilees
- Apocalypse of Sedrach
- Apocalypse of Zephaniah

1st Oracle of Judgment and Salvation, War and Victory

(9:1—11:17)

One of the immediate differences between the first and second sections of Zechariah are that while the first section has a sense of immediacy with respect to rebuilding the 2nd Temple, the second section seems more applicable to a future era.

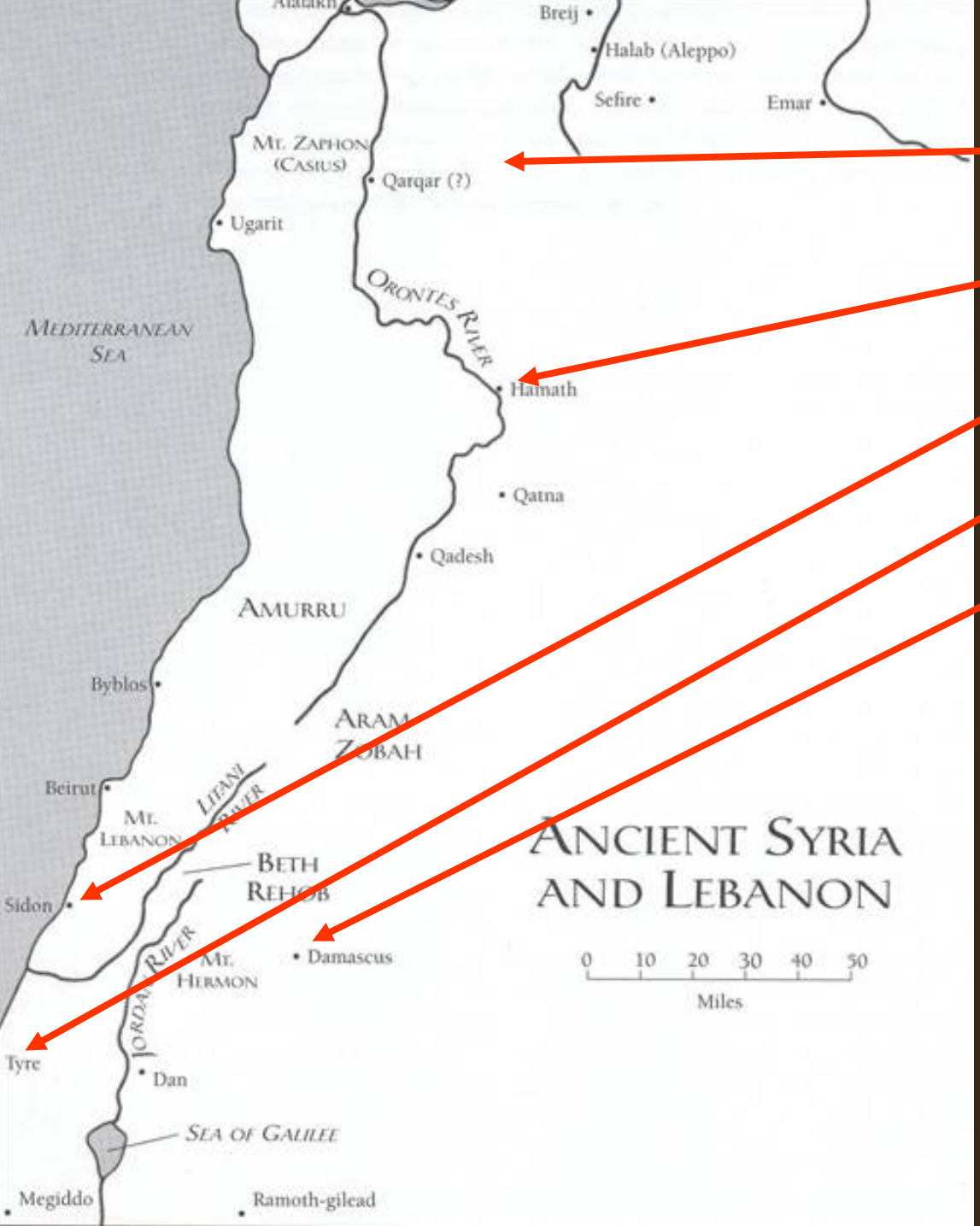
- *The second section contains two lengthy oracles (9:1—11:17 and 12:1—14:21).*
- *Each begins with the heading* מַשָּׂא *(= burden).*
- *The genre is apocalyptic and poetic with extensive use of imagery and symbolism.*

Judgment on Neighboring Peoples
(9:1-8)

The vision begins with a description of a northern invasion as Yahweh conquers every city on his way to Jerusalem.

- *Hadrach (northern Syria)*
- *Damascus (capital of Syria)*
- *Hamath (on the Orontes River)*
- *Tyre and Sidon (coastal cities in Phoenicia)*
- *Ashkelon, Gaza, Ekron and Ashdod (Philistine cities on the south coastal plain of Israel)*

<u>THE SURPRISE ELEMENT:</u> The Philistines will be converted, embracing the dietary laws of Israel and becoming part of God's faithful remnant (9:7). During all this war, Yahweh will protect his temple and his people.



Hadrach

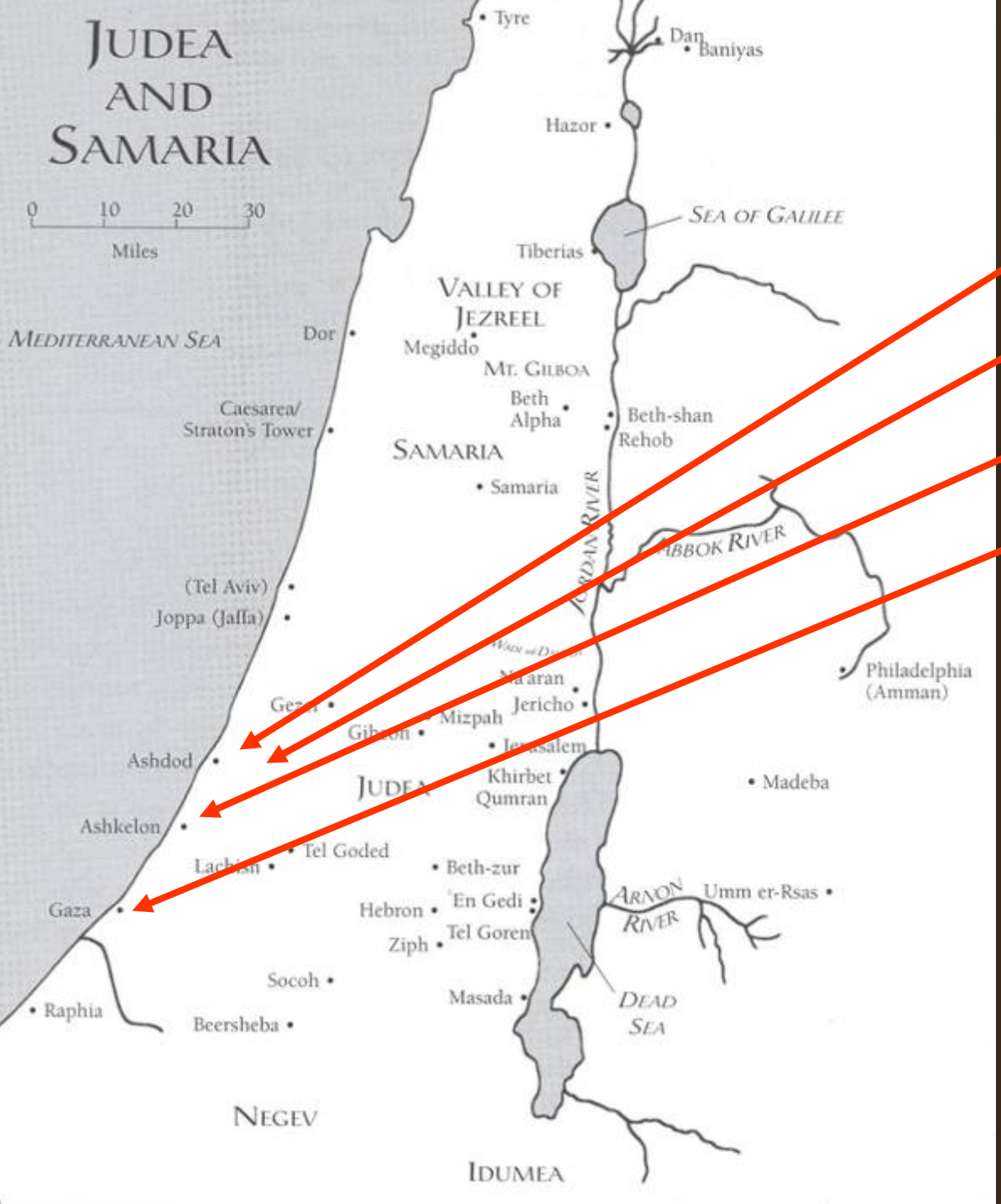
Hamath

Sidon

Tyre

Damascus

THE SYRIANS & PHOENICIANS



Ashdod

Ekron

Ashkelon

Gaza

THE PHILISTINES

The Arrival of the King
(9:9-10)

The invasion is linked to the arrival of a new king to Jerusalem.

- *He would come as a righteous, gentle king, riding on a donkey, the symbol of peace (recalls the ancient prophecy of Jacob, cf. Ge. 49:11).*
- *The implements of war would be cleansed from both the north (Ephraim) and the south (Jerusalem), and universal peace would be established for the nations.*

The Deliverance of Israel

(9:11—10:1)

Once again, the vision returns to war.

- *In covenant faithfulness, Yahweh will rescue his prisoners of war, empowering both the north and the south against the Aegeans (יָוָן = Greece and the other nations in the Aegean).*
- *In a striking theophany, Yahweh appears in order to defend his people, saving his flock and restoring them with full blessings.*

Victory in Spite of False Shepherds
(10:2—11:3)

A perennial problem for Israel had been false shepherds, kings, priests and prophets who led the people astray.

- *Without sound leaders, the Israelites had fallen into idolatry and pagan spirituality, but Yahweh himself would become a Good Shepherd to the flock (10:2-3).*
- *He would empower both north and south, regathering them from Egypt, Assyria and the nations, multiplying them and leading them in a second exodus (10:4-12).*
- *As at the Red Sea, God's victory in this second exodus ends with a taunt song at the enemy (11:1-3).*

Images from the Past Define Israel's New Leader
(10:4)

The cornerstone

The tested stone in Zion (Is. 28:16); the rejected capstone (Ps. 118:22)

The Tent Peg

The peg driven into a secure place (Is. 22:22-23)

The Battle Bow

The arrow of Yahweh's victory (2 Kg. 13:17)

Every commander (ruler)

The scepter of Judah (Ge. 49:10)

The Flock and the Shepherds

(11:4-17)

The final section is in three movements and shifts from poetry to prose (except for the final stanza in 11:17).

- *The flock is Israel, and the shepherds are Israel's leaders.*
- *In the first movement, Yahweh calls upon the prophet to act out the role of a good shepherd to a flock ravaged by poor leadership (11:4-6).*
- *In doing so, the good shepherd's primary tools were his shepherd's staves called "Favor" and "Unity", symbols of his gracious care (11:7). He dismissed three shepherds who were unworthy of the name (11:8).*

The Flock and the Shepherds cont.--
(11:4-17)

In <u>the second movement</u> of the narrative, the flock rejected the good shepherd, so he in turn rejected them (11:10-11).

- *He broke his shepherd's staff called "Favor" (11:10-11).*
- *He asked for his wages and was paid the price of a slave (11:12; cf. Ex. 21:32).*
- *With a sarcastic jibe ("this lordly price"), he threw the money to the temple potter (11:13).*
- *Then, he broke his shepherd's staff called "Union" (11:14).*

The Flock and the Shepherds cont.--
(11:4-17)

In <u>the third movement</u> of the narrative, the prophet was instructed to play the role of a worthless shepherd (11:15).

- *This role symbolized what would happen to the flock after they had rejected the good shepherd (11:16).*
- *The narrative ends with a poetic stanza pronouncing a curse upon the worthless shepherd.*

Interpreting the Oracle

three general approaches

HISTORICAL

Here, the attempt is to locate the meaning in the history of Israel leading to the exile or in the post-exilic period up through the Maccabean revolt.

FUTURISTIC

Here, the approach is to locate the meaning in the life of Jesus or else at the end of the age (or both).

SPIRITUAL

Here, the wars are treated as symbolisms of the missionary spread of Christianity.

An Historical Interpretation of the Shepherd's Narrative

Flock marked for death = Period of the Judges

"Favor" and "Union" = United Monarchy

- *Three shepherds dismissed (Saul, Abner, Eshbaal)*
- *Breaking of "Favor" and "Union" is the rupture of the monarchy under Rehoboam and Jeroboam*

Subsequent shepherds = evil kings of Israel & Judah (the worthless shepherd is Zedekiah who deserted the flock, cf. 2 Kg. 25:4; Je. 52:7-8; Eze. 12:3-16)

A Messianic Interpretation of the Shepherd's Narrative

Flock marked for death = Greek & Roman oppressions yet to come

Good Shepherd = Christ

- *Rejected by his own flock*
- *The dismissed shepherds are messianic pretenders in the 1st century (i.e., Judas the Galilean, Theudas, etc., cf. Ac. 5:36-37)*
- *He abandons them to Titus Vespasian (first Jewish revolt and destruction of the temple in AD 70)*

Evil shepherd = primary leader in the Jewish revolt against Rome (i.e., Simon bar Gioras)

A Dispensational Interpretation of the Shepherd's Narrative

Flock marked for death = persecution of the Jews in the Great Tribulation at the end of the age

Good Shepherd = Christ

- *Rejected by his own flock*
- *The dismissed shepherds are messianic pretenders at the end of the age (cf. Mt. 24:23-26//Mk. 13:21-23)*
- *The Jews are abandoned to the persecution of the great red dragon (cf. Rv. 12:13, 17) and the beast (Rv. 13:7a, 9-10).*

Evil shepherd = eschatological antichrist, Paul's "man of lawlessness" (cf. 2 Th. 2:3-12) and John's beast from the sea (Rv. 13).

NT References to the 1st Oracle

Jesus' Triumphant Entry

- *Both Matthew and John link Jesus' entry into Jerusalem on Palm Sunday with Zec. 9:9 (cf. Mt. 21:4-5; Jn. 12:14-16).*

Jesus' Betrayal by Judas

- *John's Gospel presents Jesus as the Good Shepherd (Jn. 10).*
- *Matthew links the insulting wages of the Good Shepherd with the thirty pieces of silver paid to Judas (Zec. 11:8b-12; Mt. 26:14-16).*
- *Later, Matthew describes Judas' blood money used to purchase the potter's field (Mt. 27:5-10; cf. Ac. 1:18-19).*

Possible NT Allusions

The Good Shepherd's rejection by the flock may reflect upon Christ's rejection by "his own" (Zec. 11:4-11; Jn. 1:11).

The new King's reign of peace (Zec. 9:10) may reflect upon the vision of peace in Christ's messianic rule (Lk. 2:14).

The ruler from Judah who is the cornerstone (Zec. 10:4) may reflect upon Christ the cornerstone (cf. Mt. 21:42//Mk. 12:10//Lk. 20:17; Ac. 4:11; 1 Pe. 2:7).

The wars against the nations may reflect upon the visions of John, where the nations oppose God's people (Rv. 12:17; 16:14; 19:19).

The regathering and restoration of the Diaspora may reflect upon the gospel to the nations (Ze. 9:12, 16-17; 10:1, 6-12; cf. Jn. 11:51-52; Ja. 1:1; 1 Pe. 1:1-2).

The conversion of the Philistines may hint at the gospel to the Gentiles (Zec. 9:7; cf. Ep. 2:11-13).

The false shepherd (11:15-17) may hint at the eschatological antichrist.